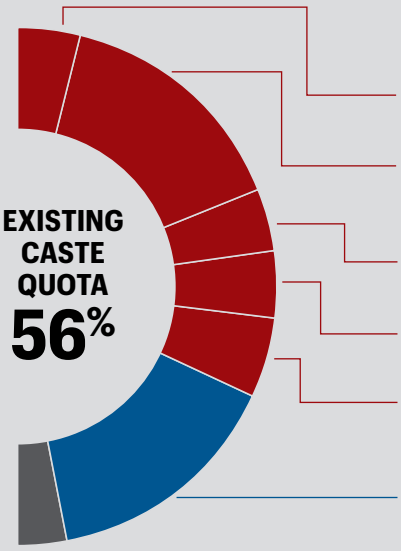
THE STATUS QUO(TA) IN PLACE



BACKWARD CLASSES: 32%

Category I: 4%
Most backward castes

Category II (a): 15%
Includes Kuruba, Idiga, Vishwakarma

Category II (b): 4%
Muslim

Category III (a): 4%
Includes Vokkaliga

Category III (b): 5%
Includes Veerashaiva-Lingayat

SCHEDULED CASTES: 17%

SCHEDULED TRIBES: 7%

51%
Recommended reservation for the Backward Classes, up from 32% now

70
Percentage of the Karnataka population covered in the Backward Classes

1,351
Castes enumerated in the Karnataka caste survey; **94%** of the population covered, including **13.5 mn** households. Cost: **Rs 165 crore**

Veteran Congress MLA and president of the All India Veerashaiva Mahasabha, Shamanur Shivashankarappa, has warned of a backlash if the report is implemented, saying that the Lingayat and Vokkaliga communities will fight together

tion. Since quota for Scheduled Castes and Tribes was enhanced to 24 per cent in 2022 under a BJP regime, the total reservation in Karnataka stands at 56 per cent now. Barring the SC/STs, Brahmins and a handful of other small castes, all others, including backward Muslim and Christian sub-groups, are part of the Backward Classes, who form approximately 70 per cent of the total.

The KSES Report 2024 backs this up with data collected via a 54-point questionnaire during the 2015 enumeration. According to it, the SCs and STs formed 18.3 per cent and 7.2 per cent of the state's population, respectively. Of the other segments, the biggest were Muslims, with a population of 7.6 million (12.9 per cent); Veerashaiva-Lingayat at 6.6 million (11.1 per cent); Vokkaliga at 6.1 million (10.3 per cent); and the backward Kuruba at 4.4 million (7.3 per cent). The report recommends increasing the state's backwards quota from the existing 32 per cent to 51 per cent. It also advises dividing an existing OBC quota category into two, moving some castes from one to the other.

Veteran Congress MLA Shamanur Shivashankarappa, also the president of the All India Veerashaiva Mahasabha, has warned of a backlash if the report is implemented, saying the Lingayats and Vokkaligas will fight together. Arguing that the data is flawed, the Mahasabha points out that the Veerashaiva-Lingayats had been estimated at 6 million, then 17 per cent of the population, by the Chinnappa Reddy Commission in 1990. Claiming an undercount, saying the 2015 enumeration left out as many as 16 sub-castes within the community, it has called for a fresh survey.

The RVS has taken a similar stand, and calls on Vokkaliga legislators to resign if the report is implemented. It's not just the Vokkaliga numbers—the figures for Lingayat and other communities, too, "have left me shocked," said Union minister H.D. Kumaraswamy, a Vokkaliga and state president of the Janata Dal (Secular), in a post on X on April 15. Accusing the CM of using the caste census as a political tool against some communities, Kumaraswamy asked: "There are 101 castes under the IIa category, and there's a 15 per cent reservation. Who has taken the largest share of this?" The veiled reference was to Siddaramaiah's own Kuruba community, which is currently in the IIa category. The report recommends that it be moved to the 'most backward category' of Ib, where, critics say, it would get a bigger slice of the quota pie.

CUT AND THRUST

K.M. Ramachandrappa, president of the Karnataka State Backward Castes Federation, and a Kuruba leader, has a ready riposte. "Let them bring information about Kurubas. I, too, will bring information about how Vokkaligas have benefited. Let's both discuss publicly," he says. Each of the previous commission reports, he points out, had faced resistance from forward castes. The government, he says, should release the full data of the 2024 report to remove ambiguities, if any. "There are many small communities that still don't know where they stand. We don't have clear information about whom all the state's programmes have reached over the past 50 years," says Ramachandrappa.

Detailed data is exactly what many ministers had sought at the April 17 cabinet meet, according to law minister H.K. Patil. Even if the Siddaramaiah government is treading cautiously, that perhaps is the only real long-term cure for confusion. Caste is a political hot potato, but the Congress has taken it upon itself to peel it for the greater good. ■